



Mother and baby homes and Magdalene laundries oral history project

Interview with TC

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Date: 16th June 2021

Interviewer: Olivia Dee

Transcriber: Olivia Dee

Interview conducted online

Warning this interview contains testimony dealing with sexual abuse.

The interview with TC was conducted online and this created some lack of clarity in the audio recording and subsequent transcription. She was very emotional throughout the interview, which contained very difficult testimony. She experienced physical and sexual abuse as a child. Her childhood was also disrupted by sectarian attacks on the family home, at which point she was sent away to a children's home or school of some sort (she was only five at this point and could not remember all details of this experience). TC's unhappy home life continued when she returned to her family at the age of 14 or 15 and, subsequently, a court made the decision to send her to a Good Shepherd's St Mary's home where she worked in its laundry. TC explained that because of the extremely difficult nature of life in her family home, living in the convent provided a less traumatic daily routine. TC recalled that she had some freedom to leave the St Mary's home at weekends for trips out. During these outings TC met up with her boyfriend and she became pregnant by him and gave birth to a baby boy at the age of 17. This was in the 1970s.

After TC gave birth she was sent to a mother and baby institution operated by social services for several weeks. TC describes how she defied her mother's demand that her son should be adopted. She was encouraged to do so by a doctor she met in the maternity ward who was the first person to suggest that TC could keep her baby. The positive interaction with this doctor contrasts with what she remembers of the midwife's attitude towards her as an unmarried

mother. TC, thereafter, insisted that she keep him and raised the boy herself. Subsequently, she managed to secure a flat to live in.

To ensure TC's anonymity names of individuals, some locations and other details have been removed. Redactions are indicated by **.

[Recording begins]

TC: Yeah.

OD: And if you want me to stop you'll hear it cause it'll say that. Just ... just for the tape it is the 16th of June 2021 and I'm Olivia Dee and I'm here with an interviewee for the Northern Ireland mother and baby home and Magdalene laundry project. The second half of the project, so this is the summer extension where we do some ... some of the interviews for people that have come forward since we published the report. So we've ... we've been through, and you're happy for me to record?

TC: Yeah.

OD: And you're happy that I'll stop anytime you want to stop and all ... all of that and we're going to be anonymous so please don't worry anything ... anything that you say that you're worrying might identify you we can take out later, so just...

TC: Yeah.

OD: We'll ... we'll go at your speed. So, we've had a bit of a chat before we started the tape about your experience and stuff but ... and we've also talked about missing memories or gaps in your memory so anytime we hit one of those just feel free to move on. I won't, kind of, push you on that, you know, and anything ... anytime you're not comfortable we'll move on as well.

TC: OK.

OD: I suppose my first question is what is your connection to this project? What ... what ... what is it that you experienced that brought you here?

TC: I was talking to my daughter because I'd seen a programme and it was a guy who was talking about the experience of his mother and the Good Shepherd laundries and ... and it just sprung to mind, you know, and then when I talked to my daughter about it, she looked at it online and I said: "That's the one, that's the one I was in." And I says I wasn't in the ... I remember that I didn't go ... my mother ... the nuns had talked about putting me in to the mother and baby home which was *name redacted* and for some reason I went to *name of mother and baby institution redacted* instead. Then ... but I wasn't pregnant at the time I was in the laundry ... before I was in the laundry for a while before. I don't know how long I was before, but I was still seeing my son's father from ... I'd left home till I was put in there.

OD: OK. So what's the earliest you can remember ... because I know we had spoken before and you had said that you're not sure why you ended up there. What kind of age were you?

TC: I was ... I think I was still in school or maybe just finished school. So I might have been fourteen, fifteen. I was ... I was a really feisty child. I was

always, you know, my mother was physically abusive so I didn't bend to rules. I ... and I think that strength that I had from somewhere got me through life but I remember being in court. I don't know ... in *location redacted*. We lived in *location redacted* and I can't ... I think I was brought in for running away from home, which I did multitude of times from when I was maybe about twelve, thirteen.

OD: Were you running away from home because, as you said, you were dealing with physical abuse or were you just ...?

TC: It was physical abuse from my mother and I was sexually abused by two of my brother's, for about five to six years. I've spoken to a psychotherapist about this, so. That started when I was about five, after we were all in ... we were all in a, some, sort of, a convent or a home or something, some point when we were taken off our parents. And later on in years I discovered that my brothers were being abused as well so ... but then they continued to abuse me. I don't know if anybody else in my household was abused. It was never talked about. I tried to speak to my mum and she basically just told me to go away and I was beaten for saying it, so. And I was ... I was raped by one of my brothers [through tears].

[Pause]

OD: I'm so sorry. Please take ... take your time.

[Pause]

OD: I can't even imagine. So you ... you had gone to a children's home at some point in your childhood?

TC: I think it was in *largely Nationalist location redacted*. We were ... my father was ... my father was badly beaten up because someone found out he was Protestant. And I remember that ... I remember windows being broken and, you know, I was quite young then but I ... I asked my mum about it and that's what she said. Like later on I asked, you know, I had that memory?

OD: Yeah.

TC: And then. And I remember being in the home, and then we were taken out again. There was eleven ... we had eleven ... there was eleven children.

OD: Eleven?

TC: Mmm.

[Inaudible words]

OD: Sorry, carry on.

TC: We were often hungry. Didn't have enough to eat. My father worked away a lot, maybe ... The reason they give was because he wasn't earning enough money, but I think at some point he was in prison. My eldest sister remembers something about him being in prison. But he ... he had ... my father, obviously had anxiety. He saw it all through his life ... things happening [inaudible]. He was always very kind and very gentle, whereas my mum was the exact opposite. You know, it was Dad I spoke to when I was going to get *name of TC's eldest son* back and he encouraged me to do it, you know. He was ... but it was almost like he had a fear of mum, almost.

OD: Yeah.

TC: You know, but

OD: You said they were in a ... it was a mixed marriage.

TC: Yeah.

OD: So that ... was that difficult? Was that another reason for the ... the brick throwing, the fighting and things like that?

TC: We used to move a lot, you know, ... and that was a question I did talk to Mum about because my older brother, the one who actually raped me in the end, was always talking about what ... what life ... how horrible life was for him. And he'd an innate fear of priests. Absolute hate of them. And there were priests in our family as well. When they came to visit I remember he would run away and everything. But ... I wrote him a letter with the help of the psychotherapist to tell him what he'd done. And that was it. I've had no contact or ...

OD: Did you send it?

TC: Yeah I sent it, yeah.

OD: That's amazing. That's so difficult, wow.

TC: The psychotherapist was ... was absolutely ..., you know, you ... she got me past the point of ... oh I'm so emotional ... she got me past the point of hating myself and blaming myself.

OD: Good.

TC: So that was ... and I felt a sense of power. And she offered to send it for me and I said: "No. I want to do this myself."

OD: That's amazing. That's truly just so strong. I can't ... that's

TC: It took a while but, no, it is somebody who finally listened to you.

OD: Yeah. [inaudible. TC was tearful] Sorry. I didn't think it would be this bad.

OD: Oh you ... you can do whatever you need. It doesn't ... there's no problem at all. If you need to take a moment, take a moment. I just think ... I think that's so incredibly strong.

TC: Yeah.

OD: You should be so proud of that. Of taking that power back and taking that ownership back. It's amazing.

TC: So ...

OD: So you had a ... I mean this is ... this is ... I think to come out of this, as you have, I can't even imagine how difficult this must have been, but I understand how those gaps in your memory must have happened. Obviously,

because this is deeply traumatic. So you say that you ... you ended up in the laundry first?

TC: Yeah, I was in the laundry first and I don't remember anything physical. But I was used to physical. So even in school we used to be strapped and caned. So I really think ... I think maybe I was caned sometimes but ... I do remember a really kind nun that used to sit with us. I mean, in every establishment there was a very kind nun and then there was the complete polar opposite. But, my mum was very religious and the ... I used to remember, like, scrubbing floors. I remember like big brass balls that we used to iron skull caps on and to be honest I thought it was a school. I never thought of it as a laundry ...

OD: Right.

TC: until I realised it was a laundry. We used to get dressed in a uniform in the morning and we used to go to Masses ... we were always going to Masses. I used to get home for weekends or a day or something, I don't know how often it was, and if I didn't behave, they stopped me going home. But I remember like a great big long corridor with steps. Scrubbing out on my hands and knees with scrubbing brush and I remember you were put down a lot. You were spoke to as you were nothing.

OD: And is this ... was this connected to *the mother and baby home where TC was sent when pregnant* or was this a separate ...

TC: No this was in ... this was in the convent, in *location redacted*.

OD: Oh so this was *a Good Shepherd St Mary's home/laundry*.

TC: *Location redacted*, yeah.

OD: So you ... you can't remember why you ended up there but you think it's to do with bad ... like what they considered bad behaviour? So running away...

TC: Yeah. Yeah. I think I was in court and ... I remember *location redacted* court. I was in *location redacted* court because when I go back, I go back very rarely, but when I did I still remember that courtroom on *identifying feature redacted*. So I think I went from there. And then from there I ... I was still seeing my son's dad and I ... I was six months pregnant at least when I realised I was actually pregnant. And it's so unbelievable [rueful laugh].

OD: It is but also I'm imagining [you] didn't have much education in that, so you ... I mean was it was it difficult for you to know the signs? I wouldn't, you know, when I was ... I don't know that I would have...

TC: None at all. No ... no. My mum didn't talk about anything. Nothing. Periods, nothing were ever discussed.

OD: And how did you meet your son's father?

TC: I'd have known him from before I went in.

OD: OK.

TC: And then as soon, as soon as he knew I was pregnant, I didn't hear anything else from him. So he wasn't involved at all.

OD: Yeah.

TC: I don't know if that was a case of, he was warned off or ...? I don't know anything about that. So ...

OD: You remember ... because you were quite young. Was he a lot older or ...?

TC: I feel he was older than me, but I don't know if he was a lot older. I used to go to see a lot of bands back then and I remember him being in a band and that's how I met him.

OD: And if you don't mind me asking could I just check what ... what time period was this? Was this the seventies?

TC: It would have been the seventies, yeah. *Name of TC's eldest son* was born in 197*. So I was seventeen and I turned seventeen in the *month redacted*. Yeah. I turned seventeen in *month redacted*. I'd have to work that out now again but ...

OD: That's ok, we can do that afterwards.

TC: *TC's current age redacted*, yeah so ... and I told ... I think I told the nun first and then she told the Sister, whatever she was called, and I was brought down to the office and she gave me a long, long tirade and then ... for my mum and my mum came up and done the same. But nothing was discussed with me. Nobody said: "Where do you want to go or?" They did discuss ... I remember ... staying in the laundry. I remember the nun talking about the laundry ... the mother and baby home attached to the convent. And ... and they said, you know, no ... we'd look at *name of a mother and baby home operated by social services*. There's a ... it was a big house. I remember going up to see it. And

... yeah that ... that ... I went in to have *TC's eldest son*, you know, I don't know, I'm guessing I was there until I had *TC's eldest son*. I don't have, like, great memories of that place.

[Inaudible words]

TC: Just about it being a big house. I don't even know if we had our own room or whatever ... whatever it was.

OD: That's okay. If I could just go back a little bit, cause I'm just interested in what ... So what ... what were you experiencing? Before you realised you were pregnant, what ... what, kind of, happened to make you realise that? Did you ... did you ... were you just ill constantly and someone noticed? Or did you ...

TC: No. I just ... I had a funny ... this is again really strange. I ... I'd got feelings in my stomach. I can only describe it as like butterflies in my stomach. Like I was constantly ... I thought I was just nervous because of things that had gone on. I remember coming back once and the ... in the rooms we were in there were like cubicles, you know, like you'd see in a hospital with curtain pulled across. And I'd been ... I don't know if I had been away for a day or whatever, looking back, and all my stuff was ripped off the walls. My clothes were all pulled out of the drawers and just everything was ... and I ... I had a row with the nuns about who'd done it and they said: "No ... nobody had done it." But it was round about that time and I was ... I was really anxious all the time.

OD: Yeah.

TC: And then I had that feeling and ... and I went to the doctor.

OD: Right.

[Pause]

OD: As in ... as in like a GP?

TC: A GP, yeah.

OD: What was the...

TC: I was very ... sorry?

OD: Sorry. I've got a slight delay [on the internet connection] that's why I keep accidentally speaking over you, sorry. I just wanted to know what the ... what the doctor was like? Can you remember?

TC: I don't know. I ... just very ..., you know, ... "You're expecting, you know, you need to go and tell the convent". You know, I don't know whether he was connected to the convent or something.

OD: OK.

TC: Maybe. But not really ... that was it. Just sent me packing and I remember like, just thinking, what's going on? You know, not really knowing what's going on.

OD: I can't imagine how scary it was to walk back in and have to ... have to say that. So imagine I can totally understand how you would think it was anxiety or

it was nerves. I just think that must be terrible. So when you found out you were pregnant, what were you ... were you happy at all? Or was it all ...

TC: No.

OD: No.

TC: I was more frightened than anything else, you know, just ... you know, no idea just ... what was going to happen, you know, or ... you know, mum made it quite clear. You know, she'd said: "You're not coming home, you know, if you have this baby. You're having the baby adopted. You're not coming home."

OD: And were you ...

TC: And that was it.

OD: Were you ... were you ... were you ... did you have any expectation of going home afterwards? Or did you think you were in the laundry for ever? Did you have any idea of how long you were supposed to be there for?

TC: Do you know, in some ways, I'd come out of a really horrible home life and in some ways, there was, sort of, a routine there, you know? We had food to eat and it was almost like, you know, yeah, you know, you'd done things but it wasn't any different to being at home. You worked ... you know, my mother was emotionally and physically abusive so, you know, it was ... I don't know. I just feel in some ways, you know ... I remember that one nun in particular, you know, you could always talk to her. You know, she seems to be quite kind but as soon as other people come in, you know, ... remember, I mean, this nun was quite slight which ... she wasn't there that often but when she was, I just

remember her sitting in like, a type of a lounge room. And I've got a terrible fear of mice because there used to be mice everywhere in there. I've got a really irrational fear of mice, but that's maybe where it came from.

OD: Understandable.

TC: Yeah.

OD: So you ... so you I ... I can understand that in a way I mean, because of what you had come from and also you're so young as well I imagine that coming from an abusive situation into a less abusive situation must have felt ... I mean I can see where elements of relief would come from. And you mentioned the routine? So was it just things like cleaning and then meals and that was, kind of, your routine ...?

TC: Yeah it was ... it was like, you ... you ... I know that you were up ... we were up early and it was ... you had a uniform. I can't remember what the uniform was like but, you know, everybody was dressed in it. I think we went to Mass everyday. I guess there was other people there. We always felt different because we always sat in a certain spot. There was obviously other people coming into the Mass as well. And cleaning. That's all I remember was the cleaning part, you know, the ... the ironing and cleaning, you know, just constant, you know, the big brass ball. I don't know if that is just a strange memory and it wasn't there but it seemed like it was just this ...

OD: Yeah. No, that makes sense. So were you washing or just ironing or what kind of work was it?

TC: It was ... it was like ironing. I guess because you used to put this skull cup thing over the ... this ball and used have to get it precisely crease-free and if you didn't do things properly, they were ... you were made to do it again. I don't remember washing, I just remember scrubbing floors. The stairs.

OD: Were they priest caps? What kind of caps were they? Skull caps?

TC: I think the nuns used to wear them on ... under their ... some like a tie thing on it. It had a little cap and it used to tie under the chin. Maybe they wore it under ... never saw it as outer clothing or maybe [it was] something you didn't see.

OD: Really interesting.

TC: Just cleaning.

OD: You would have met ... you would have already known your ... your son's father before you went in?

TC: Yeah.

OD: In the laundry but you ... you say you were allowed to go home for a couple of days or for like a weekend here or there or?

TC: I don't remember going home. This is where I was thinking I was maybe going with him and not going home because I remember he used to pick me up further down the road. So I was ... instead of going and getting the bus, or occasionally going home, or ..., you know ... I don't really remember exactly ...

OD: So you ... but you were allowed out? They, sort of, gave you time off?

TC: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Interesting. And what was your son's father like? Was he nice to you?

TC: Yeah, he was. Yeah, he was. We got on really well, you know, and I met him years later and I never said anything to him. Never mentioned it and he didn't mention it. It's quite bad, but I just assumed that he thought *name of TC's eldest son* was adopted and I didn't want him involved then, you know. I thought ... and I regret that in a way because for *name of TC's eldest son*, you know, he's got four boys and, you know, I think it's something he needs to know. So I think he's gonna do a bit of research and see if he can find him [find his birth father], but ...

OD: How did you find him? Was it an accident or did you look him up?

TC: No I didn't know that ... I just met him [the father of TC's eldest son] and I haven't contacted him since then. I met him in town one day, in *location redacted* so ...

OD: That's your decision.

TC: Not just him, you know, I have got a thing. I, sort of, can cut people out. Don't know if there's something to it ... if I'm hurt I've got this ... it's really bad, you know, but I keep my children close. We're very, very close but, you know, if something were to happen ... I've been married twice and I don't ...

just do, you know, just to get people who are a bad influence on me, or would hurt me, would go completely. I don't give second chances.

OD: That's not bad, that's protection.

TC: I think I do that a bit. Yeah, I do. But ... but with my children I don't do it. I ... I, you know, I've got a son who's been going through addiction and I wouldn't ever walk away from him, you know, so I constantly, you know, ... I listen to him all the time so it's a strange thing, you know, ... whereas I can understand his position but yeah.

OD: I ... I don't think that's strange at all. I think that's you learning from what happened to you and being ... and just a better person ... being a good person and taking ... taking what happened to you and saying I'm never gonna make my children feel that way. I think ...

TC: Yeah I never, you know, I've never ... I never ever would use physical punishment when, you know, ... ever I've always said to my ... even my daughters and my sons, you know, it's never, you know, ... or if anybody would say to me ... I was a *occupational detail redacted* ... you know, I would never ... you know, people would say they need a good slap or something and it used to make me cringe you know. And I thought, children don't need that. You can talk to them, you know, but ...

OD: I think that seems very logical and I think I respect you a lot for that because I think that's showing real, kind of progression, from what happened to you, into something else. And I think that speaks a lot about you.

TC: I had a fear that it would ... you know, you hear so many stories ... like [occupational detail redacted] and ... where, you know, they talk about stuff that's very close to home and obviously can never ... that's what made me go to the psychotherapist actually. That ... where you try ... and they're saying things about, you know, what ... what you come across [occupational detail redacted] and ... through social workers and things like that. And you think 'God, I never want to come across that' but yet I ... I did and I coped with it.

OD: Yeah.

TC: You know, so ... it made ... it made me stronger, you know, you thought ... you're not the only one, you know, there's other people in the world going through stuff, so ...

OD: Yeah. And I'm really, really happy to hear that you had, kind of, access to therapy and that was helpful because I think so many people don't want to, kind of, embrace that aspect of treatment. Whereas actually I think it can be, just revolutionary and it can help you so much in trying to understand what happened and ... that most important thing you said earlier, which is that it's not your fault.

TC: Yeah, that's what I needed to know, you know? You just hear so many stories, especially where women are concerned, you know, that, you know, it's your fault, you know. It's what you wore, it's what you done, you made yourself available and stuff like that. And ...

OD: Never your fault. Never.

TC: Yeah. And she ... she was brilliant so ... yeah ... made such a big difference.

OD: I'm so happy about that. That's brilliant. Do you need a break? Are you OK?

TC: No, I'm fine. Thank you. Yeah.

OD: So I think then, we have a good ... we have a good understanding ... as much as we can without worrying too much about any gaps that you have ... because I think everything you're saying is really familiar from ... from what other people have said as well. Especially the routine and, you know, what it is that you were doing there. When you ... when you told the nun that you ... that the GP had said that you were pregnant, was that the nice nun or the nun that was less ...

TC: No.

OD: OK.

TC: It was the Sister, yeah. And she ... I remember going into the office ... the other nun had come in with me. I don't know whether I maybe said to her at first, there's possibility, but I don't remember telling her that. I just knew that the other one was there and that the Sister was just screaming and shouting and telling me everything under the sun, just, you know. It was just a tirade. And then obviously when they called my Mum up, she done exactly same thing.

OD: Yeah. And what were you ... what were you expecting would happen? Did you ... have you ... did you understand about mother and baby homes or, you know, the adoption process or anything? Were you thinking ...

TC: I had no idea.

OD: OK.

TC: Everybody just said the baby was going to be adopted. Yeah, I had no idea. I don't ever recollect a discussion with me about what was going to happen. The only discussion I ever had was when I had *name of TC's eldest son*. The nurse ... the midwife said: "It's best if you don't hold him cause he's going to be adopted." And I was insisting that I was gonna hold him. And my mum was there and she said: "No, you're not holding him". And a doctor come in and said ... she was just lovely ... she says her ... I remember her saying: "No, let her hold him." Which I did. And then I remember standing in the corridor. There was nobody else there. It was just me and this doctor and she said: "You know, you're young but, you know, I think you'll be able to cope. You don't need to have your baby adopted." And that was the first time anyone had spoken to me about actually keeping him. And I said: "But, you know, I've got nobody. I've got nowhere to go." And she said: Talk to your mum."

OD: Yeah.

TC: When I did, my mum said: "No ... no you're not keeping him. You're not coming back here if you're keeping him." So they ... somebody decided to, I was going to this *mother and baby home operated by social services*. And they told me that I could only keep him there for six weeks. I don't know if I was there six weeks, but I remember one day the ... the lady in charge there was

a horrible ... horrible lady, she was really abusive. And she had said the social worker was coming to see me and I was upstairs and she called me down. And she'd gone up and got *TC's eldest son* when I come down and just took him away. And I remember the doors: banging on the ... banging on her door and screaming. And then social workers came and took me away. I think it was social workers. So *name of TC's eldest son* had gone to foster care. And I'd gone home, where I didn't want to be anyway. So ...

OD: That's awful. I'm so sorry. Let me just pick up, so when you had ... when you had told your mother and the nuns that you were pregnant, were you moved immediately or did you stay at *Good Shepherd St. Mary's home/laundry* and ...

TC: No. I was moved straight away.

OD: Moved straight to *name of social services operated mother and baby home*? And when you arrived [there] you said you couldn't remember too much about what the situation was like or whether you had your own room or anything but can you remember anything about [it]?

TC: I remember it was a big house and it had a got big garden with trees in it. You know, I remember thinking it was quite nice cause we used to sit outside. And when we came out there was shops, I think, at the other side of the road, you could walk down towards the shops.

OD: Yeah.

TC: It was like ... it was like a little row of shops.

OD: I think I remember because I know where ... where ... where it used to be. So I can kind of picture that. And were there ... there were other pregnant women there with you?

TC: Yeah. There was a girl who was ... her father was a doctor. She was really nice cause I didn't have much clothes or things like that. I remember her giving me a really nice coat and a pair of ... boots and yeah.

OD: And were ... were you, kind of, able to talk with other women? Like were you able to, sort of, do things together?

TC: Yeah.

OD: Okay so you weren't forced to be on your own?

TC: No. No, we were together. I remember us sitting in the garden together so ... I don't remember there being a lot of people there. I don't remember there being lots of girls or ... and then I only remember that lady who was in charge.

OD: And when you say in charge was she ... was she assigning you things to do or was she just the person who showed you, you know, where the kitchen was, that kind of thing? Or were you actually ... was there actually tasks for you to do every day?

TC: Yeah, well we had to do stuff. We had to look after our rooms and do kitchen things and whatever, but ... and she mainly go back down to her office and then come out when she was going to have a go at certain people. But she'd ... when we went downstairs it was like a little door down by the stairs where her office was.

OD: And were you ... was it mainly, sort of, women like you? Or were there women who were a lot older or was it, kind of, mix of backgrounds or ...?

TC: No, it was all young women. There was no ... I don't ever remember there being a mixed background at all.

OD: Did it cost anything?

TC: Pardon?

OD: Did it cost anything? Did you have to pay anything?

TC: I don't know. I think we got some, sort of, benefit or something, I don't know if ... if that was part of it but I remember you used to get pocket money. I think it was pocket money, I didn't really ... I'd never had, to that point, money of my own really.

OD: Did your family come and visit you? Anyone in your family?

TC: My dad came occasionally but ... it was always like he couldn't let mum know because she would go mad, you know. That was the only one and it was maybe only once or twice and he came up to the hospital with mum, but he didn't come into the hospital.

OD: So you ... so when you went into labour ... so before you went into labour, sort of, in this three months that you had, what ... what did you understand about pregnancy? Were you taught anything about what was going to happen?

TC: No.

OD: That must have been terrifying.

TC: No. There was nothing no discussions. Nothing. I remember just being absolutely, just horrified. You know, excruciating pain, you know. I don't remember ... well then I don't think there was any pain relief or anything like that. I remember I was a long time in labour.

OD: Yeah. And did you have any help beforehand from a doctor? Were you given any classes on what to do to help?

TC: No.

OD: That's awful.

TC: The only time I saw a doctor was when I went down to the doctor ...to

OD: Yeah.

TC: I don't remember, you know, antenatal or anything like that with my other children ... going through all that stuff. I don't remember any antenatal at all. I mean it's possible that it happened. I don't remember it happening.

OD: I just can't imagine being so young and not ... not understanding the mechanics of labour or what was ... what your body was gonna go through or what to look out for or anything like that.

TC: But sure never thought of anything like this because, you know, you just it was just the way it was. You know, you ... you're ... you think of all the preparation now for birth, you know. I was with my daughter and she gave birth and, you know, you don't ... it ... it was just as it was then. It's almost like that scenario, you know, that everybody's being treated the same, you know, you're not any different. Just get on with it, you know, you know, if you lived ...

OD: Sorry, carry on.

TC: If you lived a different life, you know, would it have been different?

OD: Yeah.

TC: I don't know.

OD: And were you ... where did you give birth?

TC: In ... well ... I've forgotten the name of it ... was gonna say the *name of hospital redacted*.

OD: What was the experience like of being in hospital? Where people ... were you with ... on a normal maternity wing or where you put somewhere else? Where you treated any differently because you were young or ...?

TC: I don't remember being with anybody else or ever seeing anybody else when I was there but it was pretty traumatic and then the midwife wasn't very nice: always remember that she wasn't very nice to me. It was all, you know: "Just get on with it", you know, "this is what it's about". You know, and, you know, I remember saying, you know, "I don't wanna go through this. I

don't wanna go through with this." And she said: "Well, you can't change it now. It's just happening. Just get on with it." But you know, it didn't never feel there was any empathy apart from the actual doctor that spoke to me in the corridor. And I don't know where she came from or what her ... her position was there.

OD: So you had a fairly painful, difficult labour? Or at least a long labour?

TC: Yeah. I remember it being long, yeah. But again I don't know how long.

OD: And if this is too difficult to talk about ... this is, this is the point where some people that we've interviewed find it very difficult to talk about but ... and just tell me to move on if you don't want to, but can you remember giving birth what happened next?

TC: What you mean? When...

OD: In terms of, so, you know, your son *name of TC's eldest son* is born and you're asked ...

TC: It was the argument about holding him.

OD: Yes.

TC: You know, that, you know, you can't hold them. He's being adopted, you know, and I think that that ... the thought of what was happening didn't even ... I don't even think it registered with me. It was only when I spoke to that doctor and for some reason it was in a corridor by window, and then she said to me, you know, that I can do it. It made me think that I could do it. I just didn't really

realise what was going on. I know, like my mum saying “you know, you can't keep him. He's going to be adopted. You can't hold him.”

OD: So what did ... did you want ... did you ask your mum to come with you or did someone call her or ... was she with you ...

TC: I don't know why she was there. I don't know. She just was there, that was it.

OD: So ... he was ... did you hold him?

TC: I did hold him, yeah. Yeah.

OD: That's amazing.

TC: Yeah. And I was glad I did. And that was the feeling that you get that you ... you're not gonna let go. That's what was so terrible, bringing him home and then them taking him away. It was just horrible.

OD: I'm really ... I'm really glad that you were able to do. That takes a lot of strength I think, to stand up to ... especially when you're in that vulnerable position ... to stand up to ...

TC: Yeah.

OD: So you remember having a conversation with the doctor but you're not sure why or where it happened? Just that it was in a hallway by a window and that the doctor said to you, you could do this. You could keep him.

TC: Yes. I remember her saying “you're young but you can do it.” You know. “Don't like, let people sway your decision”, sort of, thing, you know. And always live by the conversation but that ... if I didn't have that conversation ... I just suddenly realised this is the one thing that I've got that's mine now, you know, and there may be a way to do it. You know.

OD: And did you...

TC: And I remember them not being happy at the ... when I went back to wherever it was. The mother and baby home or wherever. They ... they just, you know [said]: “You're not going to be able to keep, you know, you're only here for six weeks.” So that was always constantly ...

OD: Yeah.

TC: thrown out there.

OD: So you had six weeks back at ... at *name of mother and baby institution*. So during that six weeks what were you trying to do? Were you trying to plan or think of, you know, ... try and get help from the state, sort of, any benefits or security you could get or did you just ...?

TC: I don't even know. I really that's ... all that stuff I don't remember, you know. I just remember being there and then that one day suddenly just everything just happened. It was, you know ... just the memory of that. Just banging on the door screaming ... do, you know ... and then ... then them taking me away so and then suddenly I was at home.

OD: So the social worker came and took *TC's eldest son* away? And then you

TC: Yeah I think it was social workers that came. I mean they just said to me "the social workers are coming to take him to a foster home because you can't look after him. You can't have him here." But they didn't tell me that ... that ... that social workers were taking him then. They said, you know, "that's what's going to happen after six weeks." But they kept telling me that. But then this one day was just ... I didn't see him, you know, I just came downstairs for that ... to meet the social workers and then he was gone. So I didn't say goodbye. They didn't ... you know.

OD: And you don't remember how you ended up back home?

TC: No, that's just ... really, you know.

OD: That must have been ... just horrific.

TC: Yeah. One minute you had a baby, next minute, you know, you didn't. Gone. And then ...but I did go to see him in the foster home.

OD: Was he in a group home or did ... was he fostered by an individual?

TC: He was fostered by a lady in *location redacted*. It was a big estate in ... in *location redacted* I think it was? She looked ... her partner was a *occupation redacted* and she had two daughters.

OD: What was it like to visit? Did you ... did you just want to take him with you or ...?

TC: Yeah, every time. Yeah.

OD: And who took you to visit him? Did you ...?

TC: I went myself.

OD: That's amazing.

TC: Yeah, no. But even when I said, you know: "I'm going to get him back"; you know, she was just: 'No I don't think you will'. She says, you know, "this is just a short term fostering and then he's adopted." But I ... I don't know how I found out that they had to, you know ... I had legal rights until a certain point. How I found that out I don't know. So somebody must have spoken to me about that.

OD: So can you tell me a bit about how you managed to get him back?

TC: I don't actually know how that ... this is a mystery. And my sister ... I've tried to talk to my sister about it and she ... she, sort of, blocks me out, you know, quite often. She's ten years older than me. And I spoke to my ... one of my sisters in *overseas location redacted* yesterday and she said she remembers ... they were really young and [she remembers another sister] ... just saying something to mum about getting TC back with the baby and I thought it was strange thing for her to say to ... to ... I think my sisters were seven and eight, then, but anyway next thing I ... I got *name of TC's eldest son*. I said "I'm going to take him anyway" and when I went up, the social worker was there and she said: "Your sister is gonna take you to her house" [TC's older sister]' and she just got him ready and we went to my sister's house

and I think he might have been about ... maybe about four, five months. I'm not quite sure. And ... and I stayed with my sister until I got my own flat.

OD: How long was that?

TC: It wasn't very long, maybe about a couple of months. A few months.

OD: And did you ... did you start working or were you given some benefits or ... so ... it just must be so ...

TC: I think I was ... I think I was benefits? I mean, yeah. Because I wouldn't have coped, then, on my own.

OD: That's incredible. I can't ... so you ended up with your sister who had got you ...

TC: Yeah. So my sister first and then ... Mum ... she just ... they loved *name of TC's oldest son*. They really did and they wanted me to go back and then as soon as I went back ... it was just back to normal again, you know, to the abusiveness and all that. So I got a flat without telling her and moved into the flat.

OD: Was that in *location redacted* or *location redacted*?

TC: In *location redacted* yeah.

OD: What was it like being a single mum at that age? It must have been so difficult.

TC: You ... I didn't ... do you know, I'd got what I wanted. I felt quite, quite strong. *Name of TC's oldest son*, you know, when he started school I started working. You know, I've worked ... I haven't stopped working all my life. I'm still working although I've retired. So ... yeah. I just ... you just had to do it, you know, and I wanted a better life for him, you know, than I'd had too. Mum and Dad, they were all moving to *overseas location*. *TC's eldest son* was about six when they moved. So, you know, I just needed to make a life for myself.

OD: Why did they move to *overseas location*?

TC: Religious reasons again, you know, the same thing with Dad, you know. He was always targeted and, whatever reason, but it was getting worse in Northern Ireland then. I mean that was the Seventies so ...

OD: Yeah.

TC: I think my brother had gone first. He was in the Navy and he'd gone first and then they decided that things weren't working so ... but I never wanted to go, you know, [inaudible] ... I was never a part of the family. I never felt I was part of the family. I was always out ... what we call the black sheep but ... yeah I didn't ... it never affected me them being away. Just felt a bit of relief as well, you know, I was on my own, you know, and ... and, you know, later on, when I was able to ... then I went to *overseas location redacted* every couple of years. I went out to visit so ...

OD: This is a really incredible story of ... of, kind of, individually how you managed to deal with just the worst ... the worst kind of trauma and come through it. And I think that you were able to visit and go and see them shows a

lot of tolerance on your behalf and a lot of respect and a lot of ... I don't know ... that kindness that is really incredible to see. What was your relationship like with them, sort of, as *name of TC's eldest son* grew up and you became more established ...

TC: I mean. I was never close to Mum. Mum was always a very strange character in a sense. Very religious, but she spoke her mind to the point of being very critical of everybody but herself. And she was always going to Mass and, you know, I don't know what her experiences were like really, you know, but I guess, you know, religion made her continue to have children but religion never looked after the children that she had, or support ... We were always looked down on anyway, you know, it didn't matter that Mum was ... you know, we were always dressed very nicely, but a lot of times we didn't have food to eat, you know, so ...

OD: It was about image to the outside? How you looked to everyone else rather than ...

TC: Yeah we always had like good shoes. Always remember even now ... like with my children always said, like, shoes are really important, you know? If you're feet ... it was strange, you know, that we were always dressed well ... and mum was very meticulous, even with eleven children, you know. I remember our house was just meticulously cleaned and didn't matter where we lived or ... and, you know ... when she talked about stuff, you know, I think deep down she knew she should have said something to me.

OD: Yeah.

TC: Dad never said that, he was just ... Just always used to think of Dad as the quiet man, you know, if you talked to him about stuff he'd ... he'd to talk to you but not really in depth. He didn't like to go into things and you knew not to take it to that stage with him. But Mum was just really angry, you know what I mean? It wasn't just, you know, physically hands. It was feet and, you know, whatever she could lay her hands on, she'd hit me with. So I was the one that was ... I don't remember anybody else being ever hit and I wanted to ask her that but obviously I never did. But one of my brothers said to me, you know, my younger brother said, you know: "Why do you come over and see her after she what she done to you?" So he's, I'd say he's about seven, eight years younger than me, so ... he could ... he could see it. You know, nobody ever stopped it, you know. So ...

OD: What's your relationship like with your siblings?

TC: Well I don't obviously see one of my ... one of my brothers who was abusing me. He died about two years, three years ago. And I didn't ever see them and they stayed away as well and definitely my elder brother. And so don't see him at all and ... and when I'm over he doesn't come near the family home because I put that in the letter when I told him. And ... and he never had children so that was a good thing. And, yeah, everybody else ... yeah I get on with my family, you know, but I don't think ... we're not a touchy feely, you know, huggy, sort of, family. Obviously we never were. I was never hugged my life so ... but the younger ones were almost more affectionate with but ... but my ... with my children and very affectionate, very huggy so ...

OD: That's what I was going to say, because I can see in your background you've got, sort of, a photo collage of just so many grandchildren! [Laughter]

TC: Well that's my ... that's *name of C's eldest son*!

OD: Aw that's so lovely.

TC: And you can see that's my son there, my eldest son. So they're all my children and grandchildren. That's my daughter.

OD: They all look so happy. They all look so happy.

TC: Yeah. Yeah. So yeah. I'm very lucky, you know, I really am.

OD: You're very lucky but also you put that out, you know, you ... you created that family. That says a lot about you as well as, you know, it is luck but it's also, you know, you have a giant photo frame with smiling family members and that's so lovely to see.

TC: Well, it is when you look at, you know, family, as in what my family was like, you know. I ... I made opportunities, you know, and, I don't know if back then, you could make opportunities, you know, that ... you know, it wasn't seen to be affectionate or, you know, it was whatever happened in that children's home to everybody...

OD: Yeah.

TC: you know, really turned our life around, you know. That ... and sadly, you know, there were things happened there too that I don't know about or nobody's talked about that but ...

OD: Do you remember the name of the children's home?

TC: No. I was about ... I was five, so I remember when we were just going back, sort of thinking that it was in ... it was in *location redacted* I think they called it? And ... where we were taken away because that's where ... the thing where my dad was really badly beaten up.

OD: Yeah.

TC: And ... and the boys and girls were separated, you know, so I remember like seeing one of my brothers and crying to get to him over the fence. I don't know how long we were there but again I remember you were dressed up in the uniform and you were taken somewhere. So, obviously it was a convent type place. I don't remember any, you know ... not being nice. Again, it was like you were fed and you were clothed and, you know ... well I don't remember any badness there, but obviously there was stuff going on there that I wasn't aware of.

OD: It's just useful to think of the time period in the home in case if it, kind of, comes up anywhere else but don't worry about the name. I'm sure we can probably, kind of, research that anyway.

TC: Yeah.

OD: You have given me such an incredible, easy to follow, chronological story of ... of what happened to you and I can't thank you enough for that because that's not ...

TC: Thank you. It was good to get it out there and ...

OD: Well I just wanted to ask if you had anything else that you wanted to talk about or say before we finish because I would, you know, I ... I think that that covered the ... the chronology of everything but I wondered if there was anything we haven't covered that you thought was important?

TC: No, it's just that the, you know, I need to know really what happened ... you know, how that happened, you know? How they would just come and take a baby away from you or ...? And for my son's sake it would be nice to say something to him well, you know, this is how it happened.

OD: Yeah.

TC: You know, this was what ... the way things were at the time and this was, you know ... he says to me, you know: "mum, you were young. It's just one those things" ... Well *he is age redacted* so ... so it's been ... and he's an *occupation redacted*, so he's done extremely well in his life. He says it doesn't really matter, you know. It would be nice, he said, to find out if dad was ... was told stay away from you or there was something going on that made him not be there so ... so that's something, Livi, that I'll look into a little bit further or [inaudible].

OD: So, I think that ... that's something that I really like asking at the end of these interviews is what it is that people would like to happen? And obviously now that we've ... I don't know if you've seen it? So, we have this giant report that came out and one of the things that ... that we had said in it was that there were ... there were still lots of unanswered questions that we wanted answered and that's why they're doing this further inquiry¹ and that's why we're

¹ A reference to the consultations taking place at that point, in summer 2021, about the format for a further Truth Recovery Process and public inquiry into Northern Ireland's mother and baby institutions, Magdalene laundries, and Workhouses.

continuing these interviews, is because lots of people want access to records or they want help finding people. You, I'm so happy to say, kept hold of your child and were able to see him and be his mother but still have so many questions that I'm sure you want to know. Like you said, you know, who ... who came and took him away? What was ... what was your ... what was your partner at the time told? All these different aspects of things that probably need to be recognised. And more than ever, as well, I think it needs to be recognised what you went through, which was horrific and you came out of it with the family, like I said, a family full of, you know.

TC: Yeah ...

OD: Who've done so well and you've done so well and...

TC: But I think in a way it's, sort of, make or break. I think, you know, to be a *occupational detail redacted* was part of me seeing life that other people gone through, you know? I mean, you know, we were connected with social workers who needed to go into homes that were going through horrendous things but then there's somebody. People take note now of things. They see things and they pick up on it, you know? And I do think back then they didn't have that. There wasn't the people about that dealt with that or they saw people as the lower end of society, you know. I think especially in Ireland, you know, we had mixed religions, you know, the ... I remember police coming into the house and being absolutely disgusting, you know, like they saw you as, you know, the dregs of society. Whereas now, you know, people are open to all backgrounds and cultures you know, but ... so [being a] *occupational detail redacted* give me a bit of an insight and ... and I think that helped me to understand some of my stuff and [so did the visit to] the psychotherapist.

OD: So when you ... when you ... what did you train in? What were you a ...

TC: *section on occupational, educational and locational details redacted*.

OD: So are you retired and volunteering or are you working part-time?

TC: I'm working part-time, yeah, so I only do a few hours a week now so. I'm lucky enough to be mortgage free and be able to sit back and relax now a bit now. Yes. I'm very happy here, yeah.

OD: I can't believe how hard you've worked and how well you've done.

TC: Yeah.

OD: It's just incredible.

TC: Yeah sometimes it's other people as well, you know, giving you a bit of support along the way. You know, you don't always do it on your own, you know. It's like ... you know, again pride in your family, you know, because both, you know, my sons ... I've got one who's an *occupation redacted*, you know, the other one's a ... my daughter's an *occupation redacted* of all things. She trained as an *a different occupation* and she's an *occupation redacted* because she's earning more money [laughter].

OD: I know so many people who trained as *occupation redacted* and none of them are [still] *occupation redacted* [laughs].

TC: No.

OD: They always go and do something else.

TC: She absolutely hated it so ...

OD: That's amazing. I just I don't know what it is. And you're son's an
occupation redacted?

TC: He's an *occupation redacted*, *name of TC' oldest son*, yeah. He
studied really hard. Very, very bright he's ... and he's worked hard. He had his
first house ... well bought his first house when he was twenty-one, so.
[Inaudible words].

OD: Wow. You ... and you did that for them. You gave them that foundation.

TC: Yeah. I always said to them, you know, you can do whatever you want to
be. Just gotta go for it, you know. You know there's struggles along the way
sometimes with your children but, you know, but I think now that impetus with
me is to say, you know, you can do it. You need to go out there and look and
get the support to do it, you know, that, you know, that my son's going through
all this stuff at the minute but, you know, I've faith that he is going to work his
way through stuff so ... it's not always easy, you know, but ...

OD: No, but I think they know ... I think the biggest difference is that they
know they can probably come back to you anytime.

TC: Yeah. Yeah, well this is it. I would never turn them away, you know.
Sometimes people say, you know, we can't cope with that or whatever, you
know ... there's a difference between enabling people and supporting them, you
know.

OD: There is

[inaudible words]

TC: So that's it. I'm really glad I've spoken to you today.

OD: Well let me let me stop recording.

[End of recording]